

ployment rate fluctuating between 7-8 per cent over the past few months.

However, for white-collar workers who have the requisite skills that specific sectors demand, there won't be a dearth of jobs. Which are these sectors and what are the jobs and skills expected to be in demand over the next year?

INTERNET BUSINESSES

It would be an understatement to say that Indian start-ups had a blockbuster 2021. Sitting on mounds of cash and eyeing aggressive growth targets, they went on a hiring spree. The war for tech talent playing out simultaneously further fuelled the demand and salaries of those in the internet businesses. Naturally, the sector was poised for one of the biggest jumps in hiring intent in 2022.

But the euphoria of 2021 has since subsided. The lacklustre IPO listing of some start-ups and a 'funding winter' led to massive layoffs in the past few months. On one hand, start-ups are letting people go. On the other, a lot of people are setting up new companies and start-ups, and expanding projects, says Randstad's Shetty, calling it a "net hiring" situation. Set up in 2021, quick grocery start-up Zepto plans to add 500-700 people to its 1,200-member team this year. "The roles which remain to be closed in the coming months are technology—product, engineering and data; city operations and corporate functions such as finance and HR," says its CHRO Roma Bindroo. Taggd's Sharma insists a majority of start-ups are doing well and are keen on hiring more in Q2. They have subdued hiring for support roles like sales and customer care, while they continue to retain and hire tech talent, he adds.

IT/TECH

It is now common to hear how the pandemic played the chief technology officer to companies across the board, accelerating their digitalisation

pace by several years. And the biggest beneficiary in India was the IT/ITeS industry, which boasts a 4.5-million-strong workforce and accounts for \$133.7 billion in exports. But caught off guard, especially coming out of the first wave of the pandemic with a leaner workforce, the tech companies began facing an unprecedented demand-supply crisis in talent. It also exposed a glaring skill gap in a large majority of the workforce, sparking off a war for skilled talent and steadily driving up attrition over the past year to a record high of 20 per cent-plus at the end of March 2022.

The tech majors, in competition with almost every firm hiring for its in-house tech needs, were forced to re-evaluate their hiring and retention methods. India's top four IT firms—TCS, Wipro,

Infosys and HCL—hired 220,000 freshers in 2021-22 and plan to hire at least 160,000 more in FY23. Understandably, the sector is expected to be one of the biggest hiring drivers even as some of the demand cools off as the freshers hired are deployed in projects.

Infosys's Lobo says Java and combinations, cloud skills and analytics are in high demand along with user experience and the interface between current and future technologies. Felix Weitzman, Cognizant's Senior Vice President and Chief HR Operations Officer, adds that the most job opportunities are in roles with Java, data management, .NET, functional testing, and web development. The firm has hired more than 40,000 people in the past year, with a bulk of them in India and North America. The skill gaps are also in similar areas of Java, .NET, CRM and ERP, which are sought after across all

geographies. "Cloud skills such as Azure and AWS have similar demand, and candidates with solid cloud experience are sought after," he says.

Infosys, Lobo says, sees a greater need for technical experts and people knowledgeable in behavioural sciences and design with deep tech getting integrated into everyday applications. "As AI, nanotechnology, quantum computing, and synthetic biology develop further, we can



"Soft skills are becoming more valuable than hard skills in some sense. In every sector, you can see wage premium moving towards the ability to work in teams, digital literacy and learn continuously"

MANISH SABHARWAL
CO-FOUNDER &
VICE CHAIRMAN,
TEAMLEASE SERVICES